

works of, publicly perform and display such materials” [5]. This question of whether personal details are to become the new currency of the digital market is not a new one [6].

Details such as contact address, age and date of birth are all potentially open to abuse and identity theft. Despite the claims of sites that contain the TRUSTe or WebTrust logos, just how highly the privacy value of these sites has been rated have yet to be determined. Unfortunately, it is still the case that most users sign up and contribute information without even reading the privacy policy. LinkedIn is far more aware of privacy: they states in their privacy policy that they are the sole owner of the information collected on the site. LinkedIn also never lists the people to whom a member is directly connected to. By default, a member's network of professional persons is closed. The site itself also strongly discourages users from placing e-mail addresses or other contact information in their user profiles.

Another issue with privacy is the mining of contacts from the Microsoft Outlook email client by sites such as Spoke, LinkedIn and Ryze. Priceless contacts are uploaded to these sites despite all the privacy warnings. The problem with these types of sites is that they are located in one central point, and even though the possibility of hacking into the sites is slim, it is still a possibility and open to criminal theft.

3.5 Other Issues and Factors

There are a number of issues surrounding these social and business networking sites and one of the biggest ones is the question of identity. Are people really who they say they are and is the information in the user profile true? Members such as movie stars and celebrities, famous politicians and make believe characters have cropped up on many of these sites. Sites like orkut and friendster where galleries of people can be browsed also makes the sites highly addictive. This section will review these issues in the online world.